with the Soviet Union's massive steel production and Khrushchev's pledge to overtake the United States and Britain in economic production in 15 years. Mao wished to see this emulated in China, and, in a *People's Daily* editorial on 13 November, the slogan 'Great Leap Forward' was actually now used for the first time. Mao wanted to be even bolder than the Soviet Union and during the second Session of the 8th CCP Congress in May 1958 it was stated that China was to be 'going all out, aiming high, and achieving more, faster, better, and more economic results in economic construction'.[68] The goal was to overtake Britain in seven years and reach American levels in 15.

Millions of people all over the country were mobilized to turn China into the world's most modern and industrialized nation. Steelmaking was given top priority, but in the absence of raw steel, everything from tools and metal sheets to nails and doorknobs were melted down to meet the targets. At the same time wasteful irrigation projects were launched to increase agricultural production and the state-controlled media published fanciful reports of massive progress everywhere in the country.

The Henan Province became the vanguard of the Great Leap Forward policies for the supposedly marvellous progress it had achieved. In Shangqiu Prefecture alone, a million people were employed in home workshops under the slogan, 'Every household a factory, every home ringing with a ding-dong sound'.[69] The province's 38,473 collectives had been converted into 1,355 bigger people's communes with an average of 7,200 households each. Grain production, pig farming, and irrigation projects were booming, according to the state media. In October 1958, the provincial authorities announced that Henan also had 5.77 million people working at more than 220,000 smelting furnaces.[70]

Similar, though not quite as impressive strides forward were reported from other provinces as well. China was on the threshold of becoming the industrialized nation envisaged by Mao and summarized by the slogan 'Three Red Banners', i.e., 'go all out, aim high, and build socialism with greater, faster, better, and more economical results'.[71] But it was all pure fantasy. The people's communes were built on land previously owned by individual farmers who saw little or no reason to toil for the state and the Party in exchange for rations and handouts from the authorities. Millions of farmers who had been mobilized to make steel no longer worked in the